SRI LANKAN AFFAIRS

Avinash Sinha arrived at Colombo Fort Cafe on the morning of 3 December 2005, looking forward to what he had been told was the best Sri Lankan breakfast in the city. The blue-yellow restaurant in the Dutch hospital complex at Echelon Square had an excellent reputation and Sinha was hungry.

As he scanned the menu greedily, a grey haired man in his early fifties chuckled at the sight of the person he was looking for so engrossed in deciding what to eat. The grey haired man marched to the red table and said, 'I am so glad to see you, Avinash.'

'Kosala! It's been a long time, my friend. Look at you. You are as ready as a lion in the morning.'

The two men chatted in this quiet corner of the cafe. Avinash, a R&AW operative, perhaps a few autumns younger than Kosala Rat-nayake, had returned to Colombo that October after three years. He had recruited Kosala, a top functionary in the Sri Lankan government, over several wet evenings in January 2002. That was when the Sri Lankan regime had been seriously engaging with the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) for peace talks. LTTE, an armed guerrilla group, had been fighting for an independent Tamil state in the northeastern part of Sri Lanka for the last twenty-five years. The months before 2002 were a turning point in the civil war when a ceasefire agreement was reached between the two sides owing to international pressure and diplomatic manoeuvring. The insurgent organisation formed in 1976 by Velupillai Prab-hakaran had begun to wage a guerrilla war against the Sri